balances to eliminate accounting errors/possible double counts etc.' and that till then 'any estimate may not indicate the actual numbers.'

The nation had to wait till 30 August 2017 for the RBI to disclose in its Annual Report for 2016–17 that ₹15.28 trillion (i.e., 98.96 per cent) of the currency rendered invalid on 8 November 2016 had come back into the Indian banking system. However, this was also a provisional number.

It was only on 29 August 2018 that the RBI[24] revealed, in its 2017–18 Annual Report, the final figures. Of the total ₹15,417.93 billion (15.41 lakh crores) demonetized notes, ₹15,310.73 billion (15.31 lakh crores) had been returned, which *represented 99.35 per cent of the demonetized currency.* The value of notes not returned was ₹10,720 crore (10.72 billion), a mere 0.65 per cent!

In retrospect, it appears that the RBI was reluctant to release data because the Demonetization Dividend that had been so exuberantly promised was turning out to be a mirage. Since the government's assumptions on both black money and counterfeit currency were clearly not being supported by data, the data itself was not being released. It was evident that the math of demonetization had gone horribly wrong.

As money continued to pour into the banks, everyone could see that black money was neither being burnt nor drowned in the Ganga. It appeared that either there was no black money in India or, more likely, it was swiftly being laundered into white!

While the subsequent events are clear, what is not so clear is who planned the demonetization, why 8 November was selected as the date, and on whose advice and on what assumptions this major decision was taken.

There were several theories as to the motives behind the move.

One concerned the upcoming Uttar Pradesh elections, scheduled for February–March 2017. By taking out of circulation any cash they may have gathered to fight the elections, the hypothesis was that